Proponents in the region trumpet the ‘ASEAN Way’ as an enlightened approach to managing the region through consensus. Critics, however, believe that such consensus has not been effective in managing serious disputes, as between China and several competing claimants in the South China Sea or civil conflict in Myanmar. Moreover, sceptics often question the wisdom and sustainability of the region’s simultaneous economic dependence on China and military dependence on the United States.

In practice, India’s engagement with Southeast Asia has often been led by relations with Singapore, which remains a critical node for regional engagement. The small but wealthy city-state has evolved into one of India’s closest security partnerships and is a hub of trade, finance, business, education, and travel. At the same time, India’s interactions with Southeast Asia have also been hampered by the self-isolation of Myanmar for many years. Despite that country’s economic and political opening up after 2015, the coup and civil conflict after 2021 represents yet another complication for Indian attempts at physically integrating with Southeast Asia.

There is a widespread view in Southeast Asia that India’s engagement with the region has been underwhelming. This overlooks the fact that India conducts more military exercises with Southeast Asian countries than any country after the United States, Japan, and Australia (including more than China). [31] It has among the largest number of visitors to Southeast Asia from outside the region (after the US and China) and has the third-largest trade deficit with ASEAN (after the US and European Union). This level of engagement is not necessarily reflected in public or elite opinion in Southeast Asia, in part because of a narrow definition of what many Southeast Asians consider a good partner, one that facilitates large-scale infrastructure financing and supply chain integration. [32]

Looking ahead, there are three elements to India’s engagement with Southeast Asia. The first involves giving the region greater political and diplomatic priority, both at the bilateral and multilateral levels. The multilateral heavy lifting has largely been accomplished. Although India began to engage formally with ASEAN after 1992, it quickly became a member of the ASEAN Regional Forum (1994), the East Asia Summit